

Newt now has
A bold weight
And a light weight.
And, I believe I've solved the "a" dilemma.
Hopefully, it looks quite unassuming.
We now join the following story already in progress.

Well, after a brief moment, I realized that the problem was nowhere near as problematic as I'd thought. Certainly, I could look at the two streams and find some identifying features that would help me decide on the correct one. In a worst case scenario, if both streams had seemingly identical rockbeds and also waterfalls, I might have to go up past the waterfall and spend, at most, ten minutes following the wrong one. Ten minutes is nothing. And it was still only about one in the afternoon on a bright summer's day. It was the kind of day that puts a song in the heart. In fact, "Good Day Sunshine" was in mine. It had been jostled out by the fall, but now, as I sat drying on the sand bank, watching the water flow, it was coming back. I took this as a sign to just keep on going. So I did. I was wet. To my surprise, I found that this was welcome; previously, I had been sweating and staying under shade wherever possible, and avoiding any water more than about a foot deep. Now I was nice and cool, and moreover, I no longer needed to fear getting wet, so I took up the whole stream. The stream, by the way, had gotten a lot broader at the confluence. If I had to guess I'd say it was about fifty feet wide, but I've never really been all that good at guessing distances. It was wide enough that in the middle I felt vulnerable, but I managed to convince myself that the biggest thing there might be lurking at the bottom was maybe a carp. In this way, I was able to go out to the center and just float on my back with my eyes closed if I so chose. Wondering how deep the water was, I dove down through the murky water to touch the bottom. I

had to try twice and I barely got there, and, remembering how long it took to get to the bottom of the swimming pool, I judged that it was probably thirteen or fourteen feet. After a while floating, I decided the current was too slow, so I got out to the side to walk.

I had been walking for about fifteen seconds when perception trickled into my brain that the forest looked a little different on this side of the waterfall. And then, as I looked closer, it became clear that the forest was not just a little different, but completely changed. I stopped walking and looked around me. There were the typical pines and spruces that I've always known in Minnesota. But, looking into the dark forest on my side, I noticed that, interspersed with the pine and spruce trunks were some different ones. They were more a greenish brown. And they didn't have bark so much as scales. I found one growing near the bank and looked up at it. Its leaves were composed of hundreds of leaflets apiece, and they appeared to be about four feet long. They waved gently in the wind, and I stared at them for a few seconds. Then I looked back down at my feet. The grass I was standing on wasn't the grass I was used to; it didn't have blades, but rather seemed to be just a bunch of thin, swishy stems. I realized that it made for a different texture for walking. And I spotted a few of some other kind of tree. They were pretty short and fat and sort of looked like palms. Another tree, too: a lot like a pine, but whippier, and, when I got closer to one, I noticed that the needles were segmented, like bamboo or a horsetail. I started getting pretty seriously weirded out. I decided

that before I could see any more plants, I would close my eyes and take a few deep breaths, maybe think about the situation I found myself in.

Thinking about it proved to be an almost hopeless endeavor. Okay. The trees were different. What did that mean? I had fallen off the waterfall and ended up in, what, an arboretum? The tropics? That was as far as I could get. But I decided I was going to keep my eyes closed, because I didn't know if I could take it. Closing my eyes didn't work. My other senses took over. The overall thrum of the forest sounded a lower note. I couldn't hear any crickets, but I heard a lot of cicadas calling, and all I could think was that they were like helicopter engines. I realized with a pang that there wasn't one note of birdsong to be heard. But, I thought, I did hear a far-off noise something like a squeaking gate. I didn't think about what I was hearing. Then it smelled different. It wasn't a soft, loamy smell, but rather a sharp smell, even a little bit acrid, but also full of vitality somehow. I decided I couldn't keep on with my eyes closed all the time—after all, look where it had landed me when I closed them in the stream—so I opened them back up. Not three feet away from me, regarding me with curiosity, was a giant and glistening crocodile. I jumped back and ran into a tree trunk. It wasn't really a crocodile, I instantly decided, picking myself up from the forest floor. In fact, it wasn't any animal that anyone had ever seen before: I was sure of that. I wasn't in Minnesota anymore. I wasn't even in the twenty-first century.

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